

wise enough to grasp this opportunity and accept the challenge of the future?" As a 17-year-old, she hears the crackling words in Delhi on the eve of India's fifth anniversary as a republic. She is brave, and accepts the challenge. She marries her elder sister's boyfriend Dev, an aspiring singer from a lower class family, despite a disapproving father, a formidable Nehruvian and a publisher. Life at Dev's house is depressing, and, succumbing to pressures from her father, a benevolent dictator, she pays the highest price a woman can pay to escape it. They move to Bombay, and Dev's dream of becoming a playback singer never materialises. Their married life continues to be choreographed from Delhi by her father. The arrival of Ashvin shifts the centre of gravity of Meera's life, and Dev, gradually, makes himself irrelevant to her life, which, inevitably, will be monopolised by the son. Dev has to be taken offstage by an intrusive history.

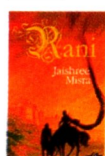
Absences begin to define her life, and Suri, with the precision and patience of a mathematician, details every throb of that life, its human text and political context. The set pieces are chiselled to perfection; the forbidden poignancy of the bedroom intimacy of mother and son is a piece of control and suggestions; and the Sapphic situations are less revealed. As a stylist, he is perhaps the least flamboyant writer at work; there is a spartan aura about this novelist of bare essentials. He is an original storyteller. The political stretches from Partition to the Janata experiment. The secular idealism of the Nehruvian is pitted against the exclusivist extremism of the nationalist, and both play decisive roles in the lives of Meera and Ashvin. And it is a novel shuttling between two cities in sepia: Delhi and Bombay in this novel are cities of a memoirist. Still, it's not history or geography that sustains this novel, and, at times, the political fails to become an adjective to the human saga; it looks remote, text-bookish, adding only faux epic flab to the narrative. The achievement of Suri is something else: like the Spanish auteur Pedro Almodovar, he is blinded by the beauty of the feminine. Even though he is excessively diversionary, in *The Age of Shiva*, it is as gleaming as a tear drop. ■



SAURABH SINGH

## A Brave Attempt

**This fictional narrative of a compassionate queen who turns into a fierce warrior exploits the interstices of history**



**RANI**  
by JAISHREE MISRA  
Penguin  
Price: Rs 350  
Pages: 432

■ **By Prema Jayakumar**

**H**istory, even when it claims to be factual, is coloured by the perception of the narrator. Historical fiction affords a lot of leeway to the writer. When the character is familiar to the reader, the task is at once easier and more difficult: easier because a lot of knowledge can be taken for granted, difficult because the reader already has a picture in mind and any major departure from it has to be justified.

Lakshmi Bai, the rani of Jhansi, is part of the folklore every Indian child grows up with. The line drawing of a queen on horseback, a child tied to her back, brandishing a long sword, is sufficiently unusual to stick in the mind. A woman warrior, in an age when women lived behind the purdah, is indeed memorable. The interstices of history, or as Jaishree Misra says, "the holes left behind by history", are always more fascinating. A brave queen in Indian narratives and a mutineer and murderer of women and children in British narratives, Lakshmi Bai was

also a woman, a wife, and the mother of an adopted son for whose sake she picked up a sword. So, it was with great interest that I picked up Misra's *Rani*.

Misra is at her best when she talks of the young girl's arrival as the bride of the middle-aged king Gangadhar Rao, who is plagued by ill health and ambivalent sexuality. The tomboy Manikarnika, playmate of Nana Saheb and Tantia Tope, remaking herself as Lakshmi Bai who deals in state matters with assurance and compassion, holds one's attention. The neglected wife, coping with the difficulties faced by the state even as she tries to breathe life into a marriage that is not a marriage, is a live presence. But after Rao's death, the intimacy the reader feels with the rani up to that point fades away. Even her romance with Robert Ellis, an agent of the East India Company, seems set at a remove. Misra's language, too, perhaps in aiming for old-fashioned cadence, loses some of its assurance after that. The need to explain convincingly the transformation of the peace-loving and compassionate queen of Jhansi into the fierce warrior on whose head the British had set a price of Rs 1 lakh takes over the narrative. Once the outer narrative gathers pace, the picture of Lakshmi Bai gets blurred. I wish the book had been a little shorter. ■